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«Donald Trump is planning more trade barriers if he becomes president – but they didn't work last time»

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Donald Trump is planning more trade barriers if he becomes president – but they didn't work last time

Research suggests that tariffs can increase dependence on foreign manufacturing.

Mark Johnson, Professor of Operations Management, Warwick Business School, University of Warwick, Mehmet Chakkol, Associate Professor of Operations Management, Warwick Business School, University of Warwick

THE CONVERSATION

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But did they work? Our research suggests not.

In fact, we found that imposing tariffs actually made the US even more reliant on foreign suppliers – and failed to stimulate the domestic job market. They also raised costs for US consumers and provoked retaliatory tariffs from trading partners including China, the EU, Canada, Mexico, India and Turkey.

China for example, responded by trebling tariffs on American cars. The EU filed a dispute with the World Trade Organisation and substantially raised tariffs on US exports including Harley Davidson motorcycles, jeans and bourbon whiskey.

And Trump's tariffs did not lead to a boost for US manufacturing either. After tariffs were imposed, our research shows US manufacturing supply chains evolved to have fewer suppliers – but it was often US firms that got forced out of those supply chains, not their competitors from overseas.